

Balance between speed and cleanliness

Window cleaning is not about seeing clearly, but about accepting that a **few streaks** are part of the view.

Suresh Menon

It took friends a while to figure out that when I am apparently goofing off, staring at the window, I am actually working.

Psychologists call this 'positive constructive dreaming'. It's a useful way to ignore a blank screen that demands work.

In this column's continued efforts to introduce you to sports you might not have heard of, here's the Window Cleaning World Cup.

The format is simple. Competitors must clean three windows (45 inches by 45 inches) using only approved equipment (squeegee and applicator). Time penalties are added for streaks or smears and for not wiping the sill.

The current champion is Frank Lauret (France) who won in 14.48 seconds. The Usain Bolt of Window Cleaning is Terry Burrows (**in pic**) who holds the world record of 9.14 seconds, set in 2009. "You can't just do this," he told an interviewer, "You have to train for it." This might have been Bolt himself speaking.

Burrows was once set to appear with Bolt on a television show, but it fell through. Perhaps, speculated the squeegee sensation, Bolt didn't want to go head-to-head with him at a window cleaning competition.

Burrows is 70, Lauret 56, suggesting that unlike the 100m sprint, the competitor must have lived life a bit, gathered maturity and understood the balance between speed and cleanliness. "If I have a bad day, I'll probably win anyway," Burrows told a reporter ahead of last year's World Cup, so perhaps maturity isn't a necessary tool. He



finished third.

I look out of my window as I write this, and notice stains and blobs and streaks I thought I had cleaned just the other day. Window cleaning is one of those activities that begins with optimism and ends with philosophy. You believe clarity is achievable, but learn that life, like glass, is never completely transparent.

The window, before the cleaning, is honest. It shows the world as it is filtered through dust, pigeon opinions, and the residue of last year's rain. After cleaning, it is supposed to show the world as it really is. This is an ambitious goal for a human armed with newspaper, as I was, especially when the newspaper itself is already full of things that are unclear. The window looks fine from one angle and like abstract art from another.

This is when you realise that perfection is a matter of distance. From far away, everything is clean. Including reputations.

Window cleaning also teaches humility. No matter how carefully you wipe, there will always be one spot you miss. You only see it later, when guests arrive, standing proudly at eye level. This spot is immune to logic and detergent. It exists to remind you that control is an illusion.

You promise you'll clean the windows more often. This promise, like many others, will remain slightly smudged. Window cleaning is not about seeing clearly, but about accepting that a few streaks are part of the view.

Now that my screen is no longer blank, I can go back to staring through the streaks.